

Skald - Quick Start Guide

Getting Started with Your Viking MIDI Warrior

What is Skald?

Skald is a generative MIDI sequencer inspired by Quintron's Drum Buddy and Playtonica MIDI Color Sequencer Orbita - mechanical rhythm machines that merge analog charm with hands-on performance. Place notes on concentric rings, scratch like vinyl, and explore generative patterns with motor control and probability.

Installation

Your plugin has been automatically installed to:

macOS

- **VST3:** `~/Library/Audio/Plug-Ins/VST3/Skald.vst3`
 - **AU:** `~/Library/Audio/Plug-Ins/Components/Skald.component`
 - **Standalone App:** `build/Skald_artefacts/Release/Standalone/Skald.app`
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How to Use in Your DAW

IMPORTANT: Skald is a MIDI generator, not an instrument. Follow these steps:

Setup Steps

1. Insert **Skald** on its own MIDI track (leave track empty, no instruments)
2. Create a separate MIDI track with your synth/instrument
3. Route MIDI from Skald's track to your synth track (check DAW routing settings)
4. Add dots and generate patterns!

DAW-Specific Instructions

Logic Pro

1. Create an empty **Software Instrument** track
2. In the MIDI FX slot, add **Audio Units > BeowulfAudio > Skald**
3. Create another track with your synth (Alchemy, ES2, etc.)
4. Route MIDI from Skald track to synth track
5. Press Play and add dots!

Ableton Live

1. Create a new MIDI track
2. Add **Skald.vst3** to the track
3. Create another MIDI track with your instrument
4. In Skald's track, set "MIDI To" to your instrument track
5. Press Play and create patterns!

Reaper

1. Create a new track and add **Skald.vst3**
2. Create another track with a VSTi synth
3. In Skald's track routing, send MIDI to synth track
4. Press Play and start sequencing!

Interface Overview

LED Displays (Top Left)

- **SCALE:** Tap to cycle through musical scales (Major, Minor, Pentatonic, Blues, etc.)
- **KEY:** Tap to change root note (C, C#, D, etc.)
- **DIV:** Tap to change speed/division (0.25x, 0.5x, 1x, 2x, 4x)
- **OCT:** Tap to shift octave range (-2, -1, 0, +1, +2)

Knobs (Top Right)

- **PROB:** Probability - chance of notes triggering (0-100%)
- **SWING:** Groove timing - add swing to patterns
- **VEL:** Global velocity - note dynamics
- **VVAR:** Velocity Variation - humanize with random velocity
- **GATE:** Gate time - note length in milliseconds

Turntable Controls

- **Double-click** anywhere on turntable to add/remove dots
- **Click and drag** dots to move them (change timing/pitch)
- **Click outer ring** to scratch - drag to spin, release for momentum
- **Sensor arm** (top) shows playback position

Toggles (Bottom Left)

- **REV:** Reverse playback direction
- **MOTOR:** Toggle between motorized playback and manual mode

Action Buttons (Bottom Right)

- **ADD:** Add random dot
 - **RAND:** Randomize all dots
 - **CLR:** Clear all dots
 - **SAVE:** Save current pattern
 - **LOAD:** Load saved pattern
 - **HELP:** View this help information
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Quick Tips

Creating Patterns

1. **Start simple:** Add 3-4 dots to hear the basic pattern
2. **Inner rings = lower notes**, outer rings = higher notes
3. **Spread dots around** the circle for rhythmic variation
4. **Use different rings** to create melodies

Adding Expression

- **Probability:** Set to 80% for occasional missing notes
- **Velocity Variation:** Add 20-30% for human feel
- **Swing:** Try 60-66% for triplet/shuffle grooves
- **Reverse:** Flip direction mid-pattern for fills

Performance Techniques

- **Scratching:** Click outer ring and drag for vinyl-style scratching
- **Motor Off:** Turn motor off for manual control
- **Speed Changes:** Tap DIV button live to change tempo divisions

- **Randomize:** Hit RAND for instant creative variations
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Troubleshooting

No Sound?

- ✓ Check that Skald is on its own MIDI track (no instruments on it)
- ✓ Make sure you have a synth on a separate track
- ✓ Verify MIDI routing from Skald to synth track
- ✓ Check that your DAW transport is playing
- ✓ Make sure MOTOR toggle is ON (lit up)

Notes Not Triggering?

- ✓ Check PROB (Probability) knob - set to 100% for testing
- ✓ Make sure dots are visible on turntable
- ✓ Verify sensor arm is rotating (motor is on)

Plugin Not Showing Up?

- Rescan plugins in your DAW preferences
 - Check installation locations listed above
 - Restart your DAW after installation
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Next Steps

Now that you're set up:

1. **Experiment with scales** - Try Pentatonic, Blues, or Dorian
 2. **Layer multiple instances** - Run Skald on multiple tracks with different synths
 3. **Record MIDI** - Record the output to edit in your DAW
 4. **Save patterns** - Use SAVE/LOAD to build a library
 5. **Get creative** - Try extreme settings and happy accidents!
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Built by Beowulf Audio | v1.0.0

Inspired by mechanical rhythm machines, built for modern music makers.

🎵 Have fun and make something unique! 🎵